

ROUGH CUT KAVEREE BAMZAI

The Crying Game



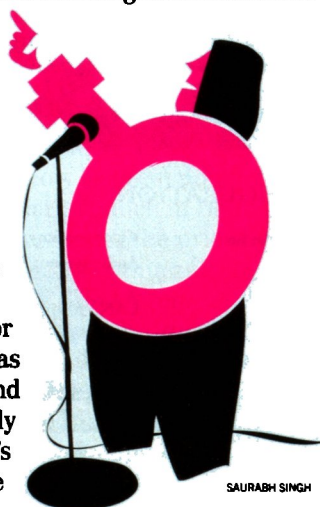
It's tough being a woman leader in the West. Ask Hillary Clinton. When she cries, she is being craftily emotional, trying to show the world there is a heart beneath the robot. When she doesn't cry, she is just being a robot. Perhaps she should try to move to our

part of the world where women leaders have proved the best way to lead—behave as a man would. Take Mayawati, whose birthday gifts include very boyish toys (monetary *nazranas* from her party coordinators and a helicopter from the US). Or Jayalalithaa who laid a power buffet (with 45 items on the menu!) for the Hindu machismo pin-up Narendra Modi hoping no doubt his charisma would rub off on her. Or the late Benazir Bhutto who happily flaunted her Chanel glasses and Hermes scarves, while trying to win the support of one of the world's poorest nations—and alienating rich kid Jemima Goldsmith in the bargain.

Or even Sonia Gandhi, who thinks nothing of borrowing bellicose Bollywood action hero terminology to attack her opponents—can you imagine Hillary calling Barack Obama a '*sapnon ka saudagar*'?

Sure, Mayawati's love for pink is as hotly discussed as Hillary's latest hair cut. And Sonia's saris are as closely watched as Hillary's pantsuits (if only to see which state leader, and by extension which emporium, she is favouring at the moment). But then equal attention was paid to Rajiv Gandhi's Raybans and Manmohan Singh's blue turbans. Clearly the West has a lot of catching up to do when it comes to dealing with powerful women. Margaret Thatcher was perceived as permanently middle-aged so the question of femininity was never raised, except of course the blind spot she had for her somewhat dufferish son. Hillary, on the other hand, has tried so hard to please an unbending nation—straightening her hair and tidying up after her husband, going from being a mini-Barbara Bush to being Lady Macbeth, from dowdy to dandy—that it has seen at her vulnerable worst. "I can't make her younger, taller or male," Bill Clinton said to journalists after the disastrous Iowa primary.

He could try to make her Indian—after all, according to Joe Klein, it was on a visit to Ahmedabad that the accompanying US media first saw tears in her eyes and signs that she was all too human. And no one knows better than us about political dynasties.



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



BIRTHDAY GIRL:
Mayawati

Simplicity, Maya Style

LUCKNOW For somebody who had declared, "I have decided to celebrate my birthday with simplicity", it was anything but that. As Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati turned 52 on January 15, gifts poured in from across the state. The birthday girl herself played generous and "gifted" a mega road project to the state. She laid the foundation of the 1,000-km Noida-Balia highway on the occasion.

The festivities took off with "Behenji" cutting the cake at her official residence. Senior IAS and IPS officers vied with each other to feed her the cake.

There were celebrations in all the 403 constituencies of the state and the same number of cakes were cut. Road dividers and hoardings in the entire city were painted in blue in tribute to Dalit leader Bhimrao Ambedkar's favourite colour.

Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, on a visit to China, and UPA Chairperson Sonia Gandhi greeted her as well. Mayawati certainly knows how to have the cake and eat it too, winning hearts of not just the lowest party worker but also that of the prime minister.

by Subhash Mishra

Seer in a Sea of Trouble

BANGALORE Travelling to the US has proved to be disastrous for Swami Sugunendra Teertha of the famous Krishna Temple in the coastal town of Udupi. He is drawing flak for breaking the ancient Hindu rule of never crossing the seas. Teertha, who is also president of the World Council of Religions and Peace, has now called for a radi-

cal look at these traditions and has asked for a new draft constitution to govern the temple affairs. He says his rights to perform the pujas can't be taken away. "If earth is holy, isn't foreign soil the same?" he asks. His proximity list includes BJP leaders L.K. Advani and NDA convener George Fernandes.

by Stephen David